eyes were full of light from the fortune of the Shahinshah' – argued against them. They did not listen; in fact, 'many got angry and went off', he says.

Unfazed, the historian marched onwards anyway, with a small army of 3000 cavalry. He managed to persuade Shahrukh to join him and ordered his own son, posted in Daulatabad, to come to his aid. A Mughal troop was besieged by Deccanis nearby, eating their own horses while the 'horses ate the reed thatching of the houses', and Abul Fazl was determined to relieve them. He marched out in heavy rain and was able to disperse the Deccanis. One cannot but cheer when Abul Fazl writes that the enemy 'lost heart on hearing that . . . the writer had arrived'.

By the end of the year, Abul Fazl was nearing the gates of Ahmednagar and had begun secret negotiations with Chand Bibi, its queen.[8] Daniyal – marching south to replace Murad – sent urgent messages telling the scribe to slow down. 'Your energy is impressed upon everyone,' wrote the prince, clearly worried about what impression it would make if Akbar's biographer made a greater success of the Deccan campaign than his son. 'Your desire is to take Ahmadnagar before we arrive, but you must restrain yourself . . . After this, there will be no delay on the road.'[9]

Daniyal had indeed been dawdling on the way; so much so that Akbar had followed after his son to hurry him along. Abul Fazl, it seems, turned away from Ahmednagar to greet the emperor – and to attempt an even trickier negotiation than with Chand Bibi.

Far from making any significant inroads into the Deccan, the Mughals had managed to alienate the one Deccani kingdom that did offer them fealty. Khandesh, being the northernmost of the Deccani sultanates, was most vulnerable to Mughal assault and had long made peace with the fact, and with Akbar. Three years previously, in 1597, the ruler of Khandesh, Raja Ali Khan, had even joined the Mughals in a battle against a Deccani coalition led by Abdur Rahim. Unfortunately, Raja Ali Khan was killed in the battle; and worse, the Mughal troops, having lost sight of the fallen king, assumed that he had deserted them and looted his camp.

Abul Fazl may have written about the impossibility of knowing the truth of a battle – 'Every one relates it differently' – but Raja Ali Khan's son and successor, Bahadur, was not half as philosophical about what he would have seen, quite rightly, as a betrayal of his father by the untrusting Mughals. So